

FRONTLINE COMMANDER

GAME OVERVIEW & MECHANICS GUIDE

A fast, three-lane real-time strategy skirmish game — deploy infantry, armour, artillery and air power to break the enemy HQ before they break yours. This guide covers the core loop, every game mode, the full unit roster and counter web, doctrines, difficulty tiers, the rank & progression system, and the game's live-streaming features.

1 · GAME OVERVIEW

Frontline Commander is a browser-based, real-time lane-war game. Each match is a battle across **three parallel lanes** (top, mid, bottom) connecting your Headquarters (HQ) to the enemy's. You spend a resource called **Command Points (CP)**, which accumulate automatically over time, to deploy units into any lane. Units then act on their own — advancing, engaging, and firing according to simple AI and whatever **stance** you've set — while you focus on the higher-level decisions: what to build, where to commit it, when to spend a Commander Power, and how to react to what the enemy is doing.

The default objective is simple: reduce the enemy HQ's health to zero before they do the same to yours. Several modes change or replace that objective entirely (see Section 2).

The Core Loop

- **Prep Phase (10s)**: before the clock starts, the field is frozen — queue your opening deployments so the first exchange isn't a scramble.
 - **Earn CP** automatically over time (both sides), plus bonus CP for kills (a kill-bounty economy — trading favourably pays for your next wave).
 - **Deploy units** by clicking a card (or pressing number keys 1–9) then clicking a lane. Each unit has its own CP cost and deploy cooldown.
 - **Units fight automatically** — move, engage in range, and use special behaviour (splash damage, healing, jamming, orbiting patrol, etc.) without further input.
 - **Spend Commander Powers** — missile strikes, recon flares, EMP pulses, gunship runs and rolling barrages — on cooldown, to swing a lane.
 - **Unlock tech tiers mid-battle** in standard modes: better units are gated behind a one-time CP payment to "unlock" that tier for the rest of the fight.
 - **Win** by destroying the enemy HQ (or meeting the active mode's win condition) before they destroy yours.
-

2 · GAME MODES

Mode	Style	What It Does
Skirmish	<i>The main event.</i>	Standard battle — destroy the enemy HQ before they destroy yours. All core systems apply: prep phase, CP economy, tech tiers, doctrines, terrain.
Evolution	<i>Age-of-War style.</i>	Kills earn Evolution Points instead of just CP. Spend them to advance through 5 historical Ages — Trench Era → Blitz Era → Cold War → Modern → Future — each one raising your HQ's health, unit stats and supply income, unlocking new units, and opening a base-turret build slot. Out-tech the enemy or get overrun.
Blitz (2:00)	<i>Fast and aggressive.</i>	A hard two-minute clock. Whoever has dealt the most cumulative HQ damage when time runs out wins — no need to actually destroy the HQ, just out-damage the opponent.
Survival	<i>How long can you hold?</i>	Endless waves of enemies that escalate in strength every 30 seconds. There is no enemy HQ to destroy — the only goal is to survive as long as possible.
Domination	<i>Rank 6+.</i>	Forget the HQ race — capture and hold the zone in the middle of all three lanes simultaneously, long enough to lock the match down outright. Zones fill while your units occupy them and decay when contested or abandoned, so holding ground you've already taken matters as much as taking new ground. (An HQ kill still wins instantly too, if you'd rather just go for the throat.)

War Mode (Rank 15+) is a separate, larger structure layered on top of Skirmish battles: a conquest map of connected nodes. Each node is fought as its own battle — win one and you cut off supply to its neighbours; lose and

the enemy pushes back onto your territory. Take the enemy's capital node to win the campaign.

Chaos Mode (Rank 10+, toggled in Settings) is a beta "meme mode" modifier layered on any battle: CP income roughly triples, units pour out faster and in far greater numbers, random battlefield events fire constantly, and the whole match becomes deliberately over-the-top and chaotic — built for streaming highlight clips rather than serious tactics.

Beyond the main picker, the game also includes a scripted, multi-mission **Campaign** with narrated briefings, a rotating **Daily Challenge** with a fixed seed/ruleset shared by all players that day, an interactive **Tutorial** for new players, and **Rivals Mode** — a dedicated series of fights against five named enemy generals (below), each of whom remembers how you beat them last time and re-composes their army to counter it.

3 · CONTROLS REFERENCE

Key / Input	Action
1 – 9	Select a unit on the hotbar
Click card, then click lane	Deploy the selected unit into that lane
0	Commander Power: Precision Missile Strike
R	Commander Power: Recon Flare
F	Commander Power: EMP Pulse (unlocks Rank 3)
G	Commander Power: Gunship Run
B	Commander Power: Rolling Barrage
Q / W / E	Quick-deploy the selected unit to top / mid / bottom lane
Z / X / C	Set stance: Assault / Defend / Skirmish
SPACE	Pause
On-screen speed control	Game speed: 0.5× / 1× / 2×

In Skirmish, Blitz and Survival you buy your way up the in-battle tech tree as the fight goes on (Section 5). A Live Chat panel lets connected Twitch viewers issue commands that affect the enemy side in real time (Section 10).

4 · STANCES, TERRAIN & VETERANCY

Stances — Behaviour Only, Never Stats

Stance	Key	Effect
Assault	■ (Z)	Push hard for the enemy HQ — advance and engage as you go.
Defend	■ (X)	Hold behind the centre line, dig in, and fire from cover.
Skirmish	↗ (C)	Keep distance — poke from max range and fall back when enemies close.

Terrain — Randomised Per Lane, Every Match

Terrain	Glyph	Effect
Open Field	■	No cover — faster advances, no bonuses either way.
Forest	♣	Thick cover — infantry hit harder (ambush bonus), vehicles slow down.
Hilltop	▲	High ground — artillery and vehicles see and hit further.

Veterancy — Units Grow Stronger Mid-Battle

Any unit that racks up kills within a single battle earns experience, on both sides. Veterancy is purely combat-earned and resets each match.

Rank	Threshold	HP Bonus	Damage Bonus
Unranked	0 kills	—	—
Seasoned	3 kills	+12% HP	+12% damage
Veteran	7 kills	+28% HP	+28% damage
Elite	14 kills	+50% HP	+55% damage

5 · UNIT ROSTER

Fifteen deployable units span five categories — infantry, vehicles, artillery, air and drones — plus one secret mythic boss unit that never appears on the hotbar. Every unit has a CP cost, a deploy cooldown, and a role defined by its stats and special traits. Higher-tier units (Tier 2 and 3) must be unlocked mid-battle with a one-time CP payment (60 CP for Tier 2, 130 CP for Tier 3) before they can be deployed in standard modes.

Unit	Tier	Cost	HP	DM G	Role
▲ Rifleman	1	20	34	5	Cheap line infantry — the backbone of any army.
⊕ AT Team	1	38	26	22	Kills armour hard; weak against infantry.
■ IFV	1	48	96	16	Fast vehicle that shreds infantry.
✚ Sniper	2	40	18	34	Long range, precise, shreds infantry — useless vs armour.
■ Tank	2	70	180	26	Heavily armoured breakthrough vehicle.
⊗ AA Vehicle	2	44	80	30	Shreds aircraft; useless against ground targets.
■ Artillery	2	60	60	34	Long-range splash damage over an arcing shot.
■ Kamikaze Drone	2	11	11	38	Dirt-cheap one-way diver — deadly in swarms, but EW and rapid fire shred them.
✚ Medic	2	42	44	—	No weapon — heals and patches nearby friendly troops.
■ Flame Trooper	2	34	30	8	Very short range but sets targets ablaze (damage over time) — brutal vs infantry, weak vs armour.
■ Attack Heli	3	80	70	22	Flies over ground defenses and hits armour hard.
■ Rocket Arty	3	82	52	20	Devastating 4-rocket salvo; very fragile.
■ EW Jammer	3	52	74	—	No weapon — suppresses enemy fire in a radius and fries drones.
► Interceptor	3	70	150	26	Flies a wide combat air patrol over mid-field, downing any aircraft it crosses — a lasting air shield.
✚ Gunship	3	165	230	15	Loiters mid-field, strafing all three lanes at once — needs interceptor cover or it gets picked apart.

■ *The Void Warden* — a rift-born mythic boss with 3,600 HP that never appears in the normal roster. It can only be encountered through the game's rare Void Rift random event.

6 · THE COUNTER WEB: DAMAGE TYPES & ARMOUR CLASSES

Every weapon fires one of four **damage types**, and every unit belongs to one of five **armour classes**. The matchup between the two decides how effective a hit is — this is the game's real counter system, deeper than simple rock-paper-scissors:

Damage Type ↓ / Armour →	Infantry	Light	Heavy	Air	Structure
Small Arms (SA)	1.25×	0.70×	0.28×	0.55×	0.35×
Armour-Piercing (AP)	0.60×	1.35×	1.70×	0.55×	0.85×
High Explosive (HE)	1.30×	1.15×	0.72×	0.30×	1.45×

Damage Type ↓ / Armour →	Infantry	Light	Heavy	Air	Structure
Anti-Air (AA)	0.35×	0.50×	0.30×	2.40×	0.20×

In short: **small arms** shred infantry but ping off tanks; **armour-piercing** rounds kill armour but waste themselves on infantry; **high explosive** clears groups and levels structures/HQs; **anti-air** owns the sky and is nearly useless against anything grounded. Precision units like the Sniper also land occasional critical hits for double damage.

7 · DOCTRINES

Before a battle you pick one **Doctrine** — a persistent army-wide perk for that match. Doctrines unlock progressively by Commander Rank (0 = available from the start).

Doctrine	Unlocks At	Effect
Blitzkrieg	Rank 0	Vehicles cost 20% less and move faster — punch a hole and pour through it.
Mass Assault	Rank 0	Infantry cost 30% less and CP income is higher — quantity has a quality all its own.
Air Dominant	Rank 2	Aircraft cost 25% less and hit 25% harder.
Deep Fires	Rank 3	Artillery costs 25% less, hits 30% harder, and your missile strike reloads faster.
Precision Strike	Rank 4	All units deal +18% damage and your missile strike recharges faster.
Recon-Pull	Rank 5	Spotting range doubled (fog/rain never blind you) and +10% damage on the opening exchange.
Drone Swarm	Rank 6	Drones cost 40% less and deploy faster — drown the enemy in attritable airframes.
Insurgency	Rank 7	Infantry cost 40% less, are far harder to spot, and land an ambush-damage bonus.
Defense in Depth	Rank 8	HQ has +40% health and every unit is +25% tougher — let them break on your line.

8 · DIFFICULTY TIERS

Tier	AI Behaviour	Best For
■ Recruit	Generous — bonus starting CP for the player, a slower and simpler AI that opens light.	Learning the ropes.
■■ Veteran	Balanced, roughly even economy; the AI plays it straight without any special tricks.	The standard challenge.
■■■ Elite	The AI gets a real economic edge, reacts faster, and starts using smart behaviour — focus-fire, hard-countering your composition, and hoarding budget for the right moment.	For players who've beaten Veteran.
■ Legendary	"Ultimate mode" — a large economic and stat advantage, the fastest and most aggressive AI, opens with 8 units, and commits its budget tightly to punch your weakest lane.	The hardest fight in the game.

9 · RANK & PROGRESSION

Winning and playing battles earns XP, which advances your **Commander Rank** from 1 up to a hard cap of **100**. Rank is entirely cosmetic-plus-gating: the full unit roster and every doctrine unlock early (by around Rank 8), so progression never gatekeeps basic gameplay — but it does gate three whole modes and dozens of collectible rewards, giving the climb to 100 real teeth.

What Rank Unlocks

- **23 Commander Titles**, from Recruit (Rank 1) up through Colonel, General, Field Marshal, Warlord, and finally **Five-Star Legend** at Rank 100.
- **22 HQ Badges**, cosmetic emblems from ■ Crossed Sabers (Rank 1) to ■ Apex Commander (Rank 100), each with its own name and flavour.
- **Commendations** — every rank that isn't already a title, badge, doctrine, or mode unlock still rewards a tiered commendation, so there is always something to earn at every single rank, all the way to 100.
- **Mode unlocks**: Domination Mode at Rank 6, Chaos Mode at Rank 10, War Mode at Rank 15.
- **EMP Pulse** commander power unlocks at Rank 3.
- Players can equip any previously-earned title or badge, not just their current one — pin your favourite instead of always showing the newest.

A **visual rank-progression map** on the Roadmap screen lays out the entire path to Rank 100 so players can see what's coming next and how far off it is. For playtesting, the title screen includes a **"Debug: Unlock All"** toggle that bypasses every rank gate instantly, so testers can reach Domination, Chaos and War Mode without grinding.

10 · RIVAL GENERALS, STREAMING & LIVE CHAT INTEGRATION

Rival Generals

Five named AI commanders can appear as your opponent, each with a signature style, intro line, in-battle taunts, and a loss line: **Gen. Korvinov "Steel Fist"** (armour-heavy), **Col. Reyes "Ghost Wing"** (drone swarms), **Marshal Dubois "Long Reach"** (artillery), **Col. Voss "Rolling Thunder"** (rocket artillery), and **Air Marshal Bakr "Sky Reaper"** (helicopters). In Rivals Mode specifically, each general remembers the last composition you beat them with and adapts their next army to counter it.

Twitch Chat Integration

The game can connect anonymously to a Twitch channel's chat over IRC. Once connected, viewers can type commands that directly affect the match:

- **top / mid / bot** — vote to surge reinforcements into that lane.
- **boss, drop, hype** — trigger battlefield events once enough viewers pile on.
- **chaos** (or *event / roll*) — chat rolls the dice for a random battlefield event.
- Big chat-wide chants, requiring a growing tally of unique callers: **fortify** (16), **storm** (22), **blitz** (26), and **NUKE** (50) — which wipes the whole field.

A separate set of **information-warfare / streamer-troll powers** (phantom units, gaslighting UI messages, fog-outs, ghost pings, colour-drain, tunnel vision, UI jumble, and fake donation alerts) can be triggered by chat as well, for chaotic, clip-worthy stream moments distinct from the straightforward lane-vote commands above.

Streamer Mode & Presentation

- An AI war-room **narrator** delivers spoken (and subtitled) battle commentary, with an optional premium AI voice via a user-supplied ElevenLabs API key (stored encrypted).
- A generated **fake-news ticker** reacts to real battle state with plausible headlines.
- Original procedural music shifts between menu, battle, and victory themes.
- Random rare battlefield events (glitches, a shadow entity, a Void Rift that can spawn the secret Void Warden boss) add unpredictable, streamable moments to any match.

This document reflects Frontline Commander v1.8.0 and is intended as a playtesting reference — mechanics, numbers and unlock thresholds may continue to evolve during development.